Do bureaucrats vote for the dictatorships that employ them?

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Background

Authoritarians occassionally do semi-competitive elections

Bureaucrats are relatively easier voters to coerce

There is little evidence that secret ballots are violated (Hicken and Nathan 2022)

We might think bureaucrats will not risk their jobs by voting against their employer

Theory

I argue, whether bureaucrats vote against their employer depends on:
1. Risk of facing negative outcomes, based on rank and political salience of the agency
2. Risk tolerance (Kam 2012)

Negative outcomes: authoritarian retaliation, loss of power and wealth after democratization, being prosecuted during transitional justice trials

Risk of negative outcomes

	High Political Salience	Low Political Salience
High-rank	Highest risk	Lower risk
Low-rank	Lower risk	Lowest risk

Motivation

Whether bureaucrats vote for authoritarians or not matters because authoritarians use semi-competitive elections to legitimize their governments

If even the employees of the state do not support authoritarians, we can have hope for the restoration of democracy

Hypotheses

1. Alternative incentives: State employment, even under authoritarianism, does not guarantee support for the incumbent
2. Rank-based heterogeneous effects: Higher-rank bureaucrats are more likely to vote for the incumbent than lower-rank bureaucrats
    - Higher benefits, higher risk

Context

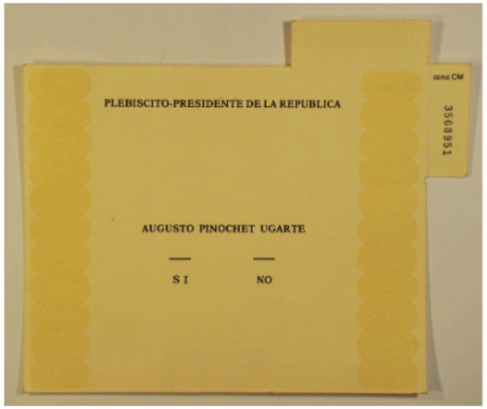
In 1988, there was a plebiscite in Chile asking whether citizens wanted the continuation of the dictatorship or not

YES ⟶ Vote in favor of Pinochet staying

NO ⟶ Vote to change leaders, democratization

Context

With nearly 56%, Pinochet lost and Chile has been a democracy ever since



Data

1. 1992 census data
   The census asks municipality of residence in 1987, one year before the plebiscite. It also asks occupation, years of school, and education type. I created municipality-level proportions*
2. 1988 municipality-level voting records
   Municipality-level voting data from the National Electoral Service (SERVEL), as well municipality-level control variables from Bautista el al. (2021)

Identification

Relies on conditional ignorability:

I assume that conditional on my controls, the *proportion of bureaucrats* among the municipality population and the *rank-composition of the bureaucracy* is as if random

I assume no unmeasured confounding (difficult)
- I do sensitivity tests at the end

Analysis

Controls: Logged distance to regional capital, share of left-wing votes in the latest democratic election (1970), population, share of victims across time relative to 1970 population

I am using OLS regressions with:

- Weights by municipality population
- Province fixed effects
- CR2 standard errors

First specification: Bureaucrats

$$Y_m = \alpha + \beta(\textbf{Prop. Bureaucrat})_m + X_m + \lambda_p + \varepsilon_m$$

Tests *alternative incentives*: State employment, even under authoritarianism, does not guarantee electoral support for the incumbent

Expectation: The population of bureaucrats in the municipality should have no effect in the dictatorship's voteshare

Second specification

$$Y_m = \alpha + \beta_1(\text{Share High Rank B.})_m + \beta_2(\text{Share Mid Rank B.})_m + X_m + \lambda_p + \varepsilon_m$$

Rank variables based on years of schooling:

- High-rank: College or more
- Mid-rank: High school or more
- Low-rank: Did not start high school

Second specification

$$Y_m = \alpha + \beta_1(\text{Share High Rank B.})_m + \beta_2(\text{Share Mid Rank B.})_m + X_m + \lambda_p + \varepsilon_m$$

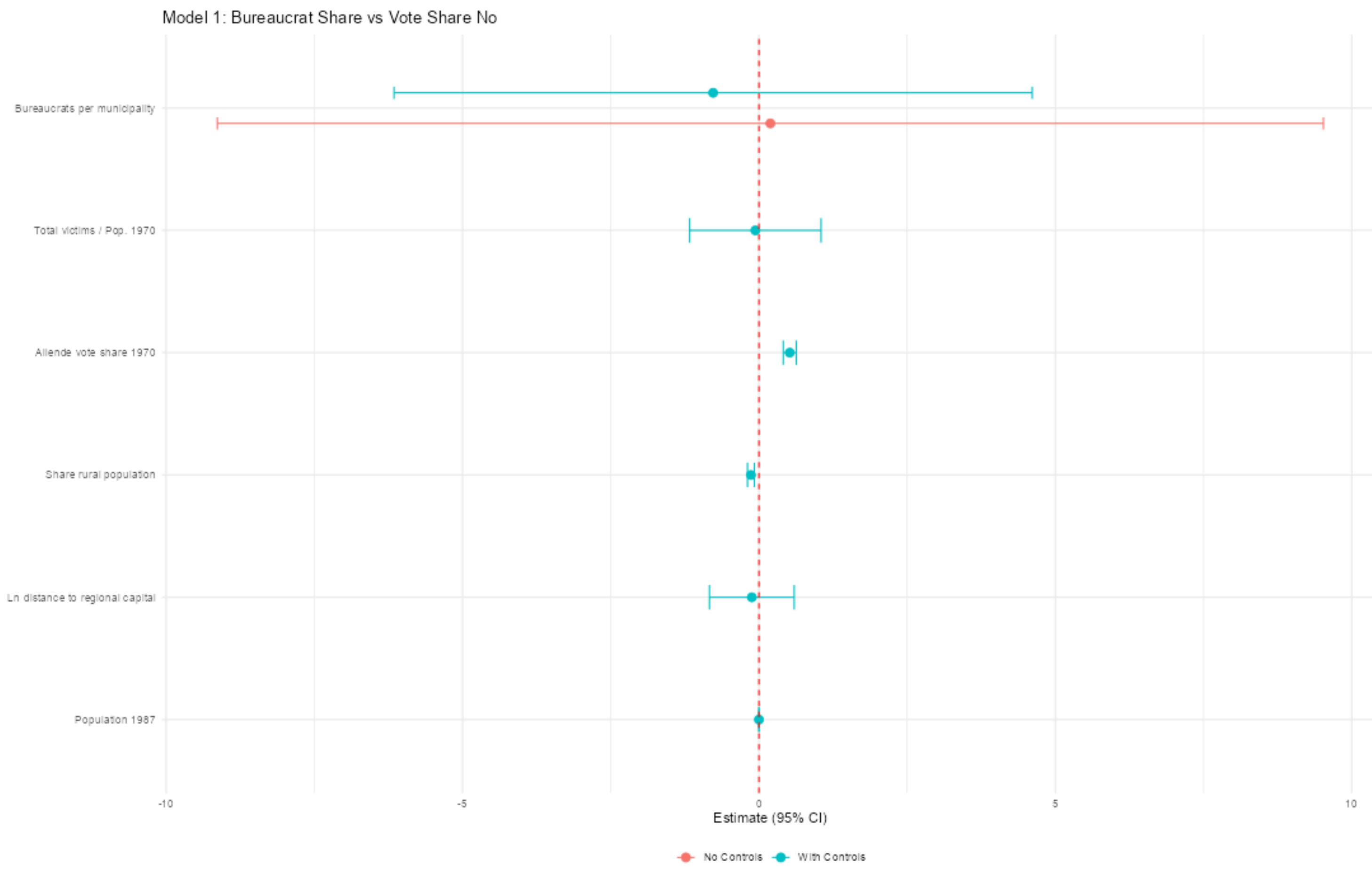
Tests *heterogeneous effects*: Higher-rank bureaucrats are more likely to vote for the incumbent than lower-rank bureaucrats

Expectation: The high-rank coefficient should be negative, less support for opposition

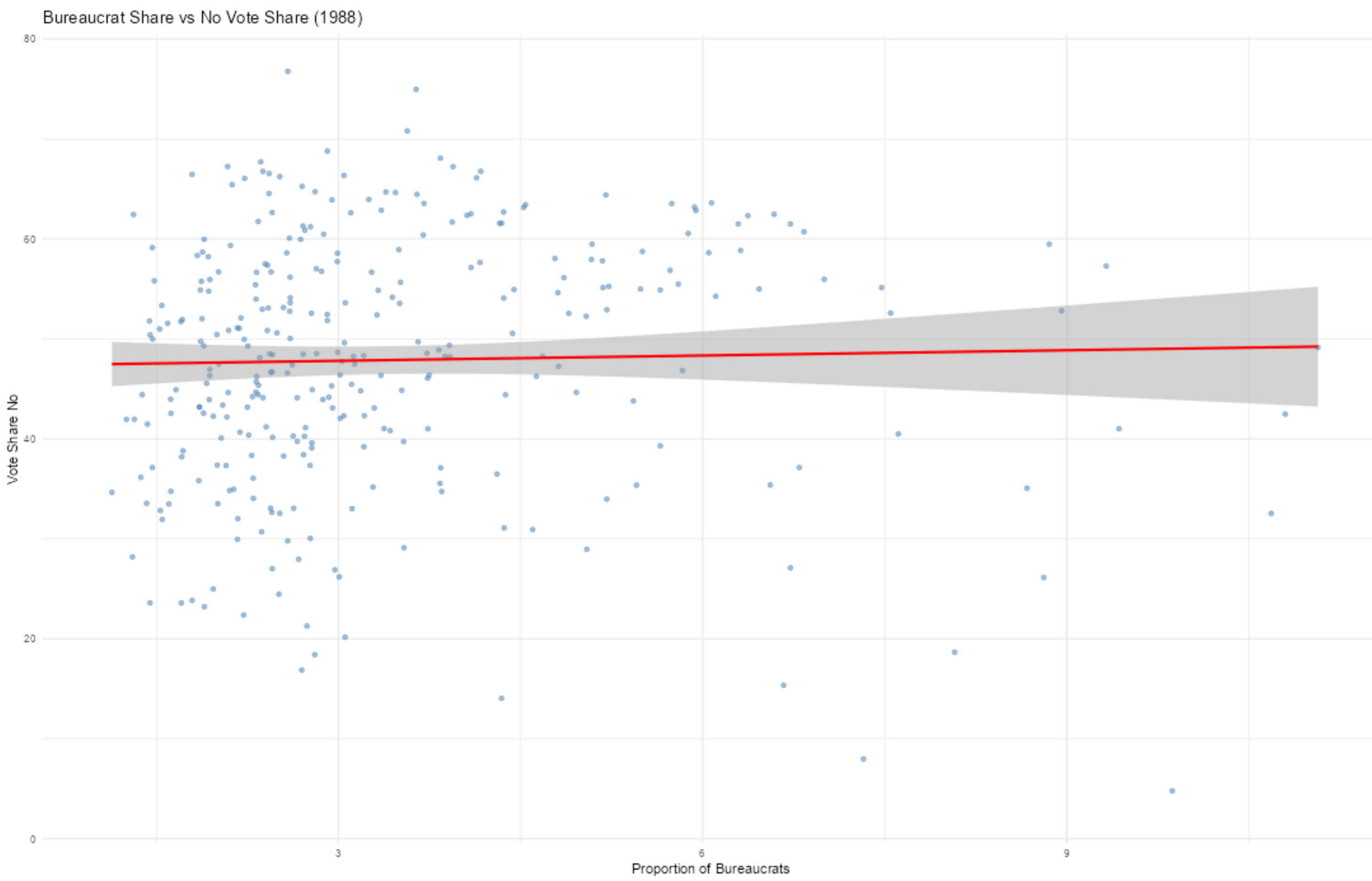
Results of both hypotheses

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Proportion of bureaucrats	-1.2088	-1.3819		
	(0.9650)	(0.3560)		
High rank share			0.1774	-0.0611
			(0.0874)	(0.1087)
Mid rank share			0.6323	0.1111
			(0.1396)	(0.0859)
Num.Obs.	274	269	274	269
R2	0.420	0.773	0.524	0.764

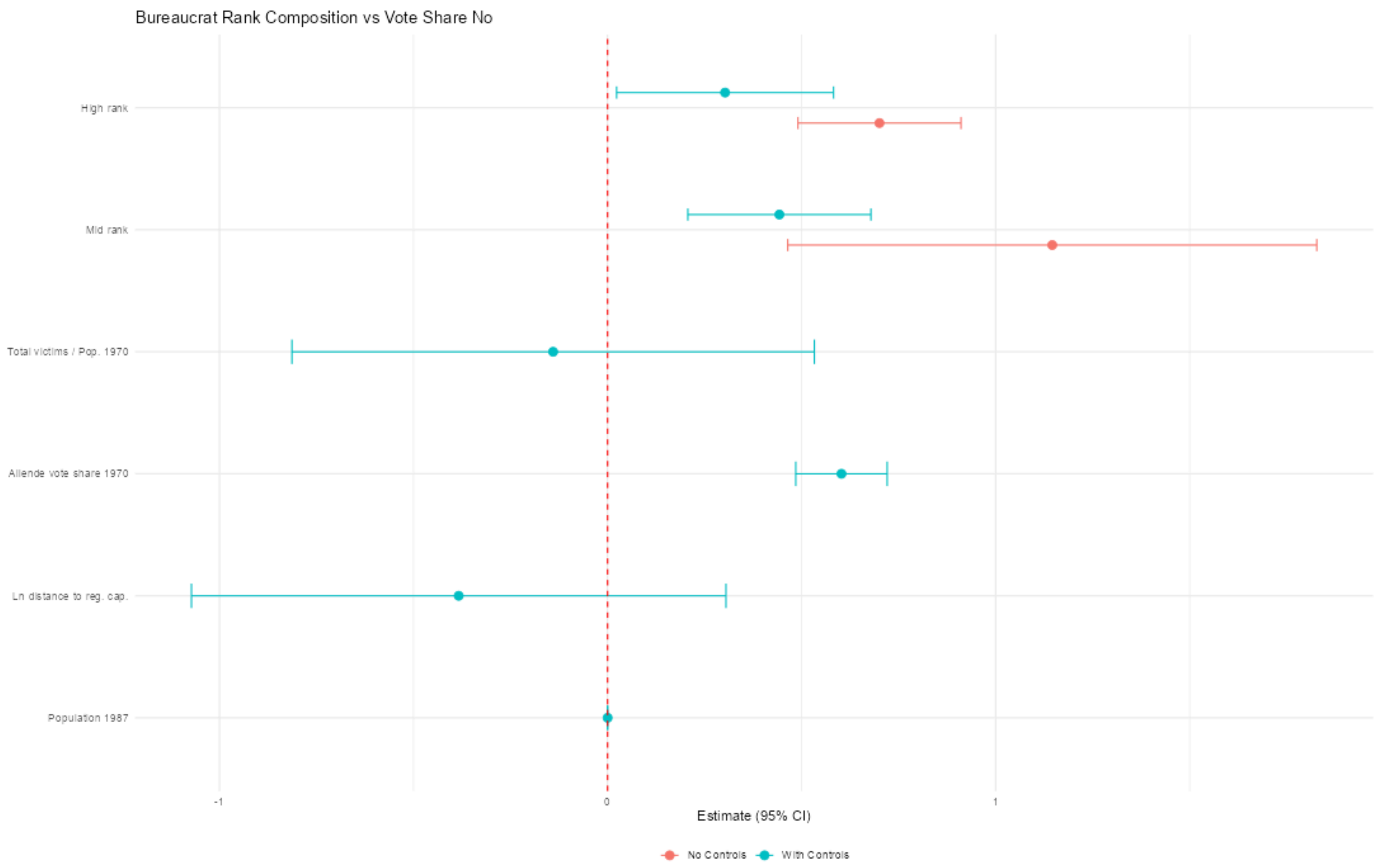
Results: Alternative incentives



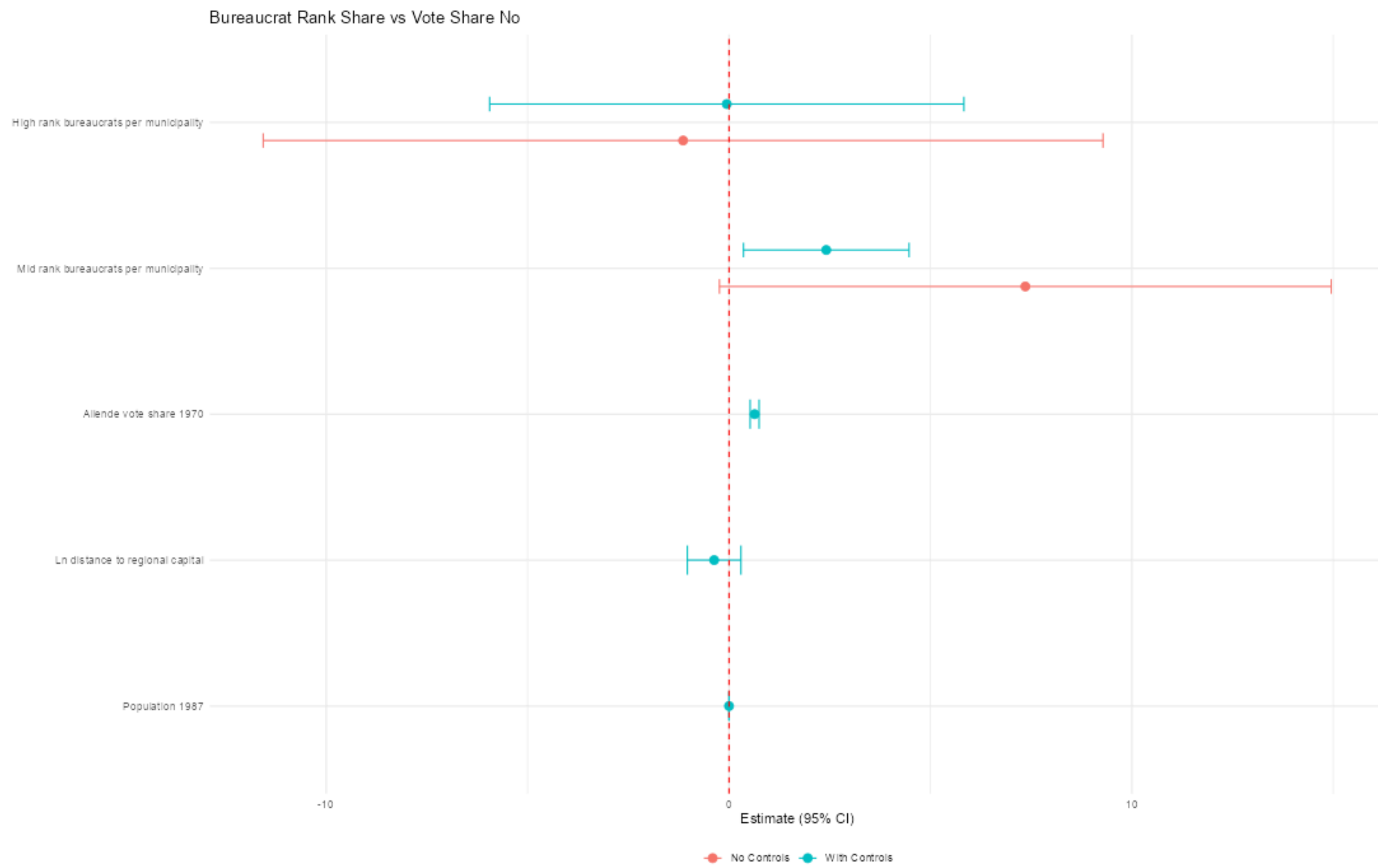
Results: Alternative incentives



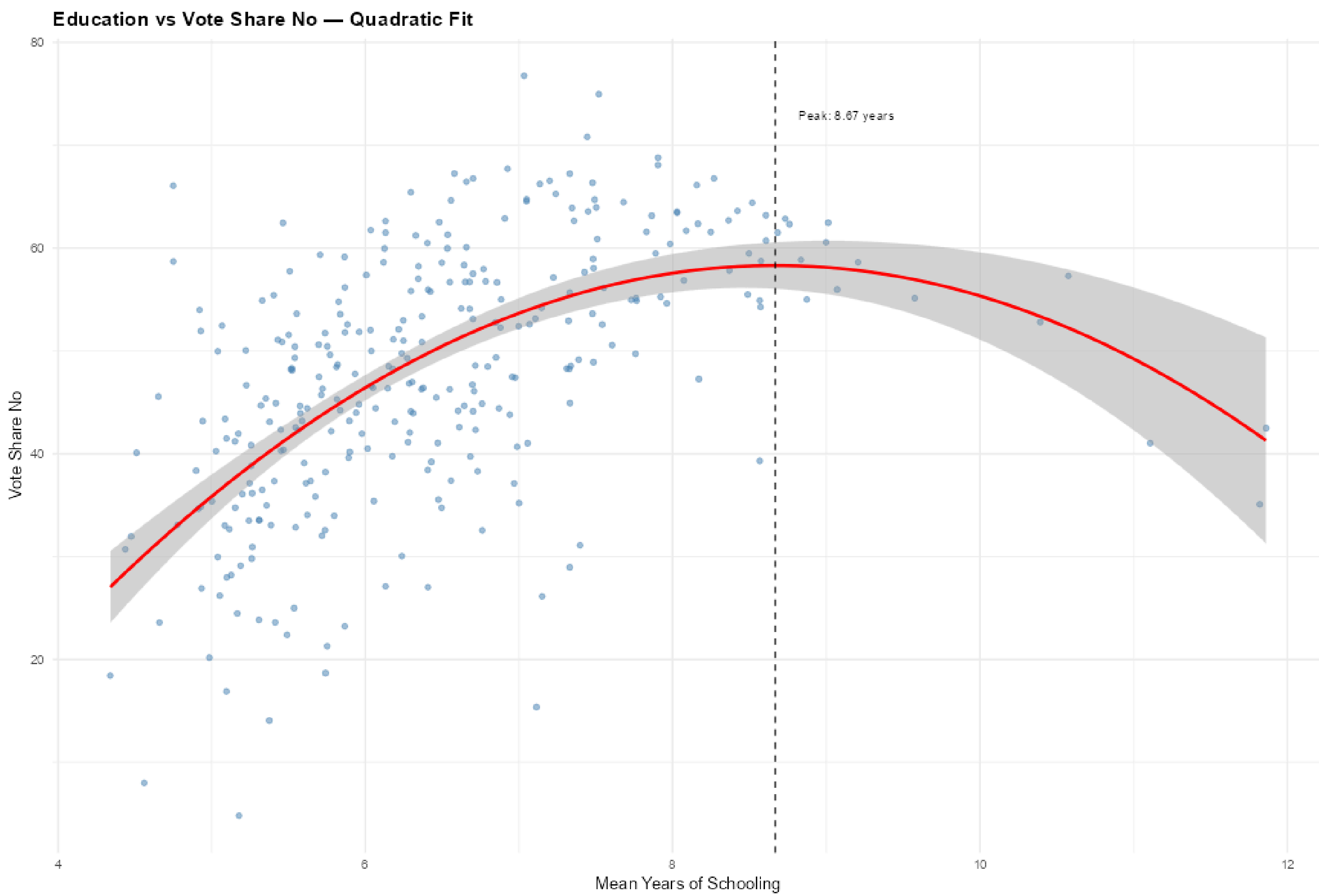
Results: Rank-based heterogeneous effects



Heterogenous effects, other specification



Plotting education and vote share “No”



Sensitivity test: Rank-based effects

First specification

Model	Estimate	SE	Partial R^2 (D)	RV (sig.)	RV (zero)
High-rank bureaucrats	0.3028	0.0765	0.0615	0.1204	0.2253
Mid-rank bureaucrats	0.4427	0.0972	0.0799	0.1536	0.2544

Sensitivity test: Mid rank bureaucrats

Model	Estimate	SE	Partial R^2 (D)	RV (sig.)	RV (zero)
Share among bureaucrats	0.4427	0.0972	0.0799	0.1536	0.2544
Share of total population	2.4130	0.7616	0.0401	0.0742	0.1847

Problems

1. Some of my covariates are post-plebiscite
    - Location data is pre-plebiscite, but occupation data is post-plecisbite
    - It’s unclear which bureaucrats worked for both governments
    - Major issue; I need new data
2. It’s hard to disentangle mechanisms for the difference between ranks
3. Bad proxy: The correlation between voting behavior and education is not the expected one

Questions/feedback

1. What other unmeasured confounders can you think of?
2. What do you think of the hypotheses? Do they seem to pan out in the cases you're familiar with?
3. Are there any ways to improve my paper with the data limitations I have today?

What I would like to do next

Pinochet's bureaucrats are still alive; I want to ask them who they voted for

To do so → Randomized response technique

The respondent throws a dice and is instructed: answer "yes" if the dice rolls 1, "no" if the dice rolls 6, the truth if the dice rolls 2, 3, or 4

The problems are sampling and social desirability bias

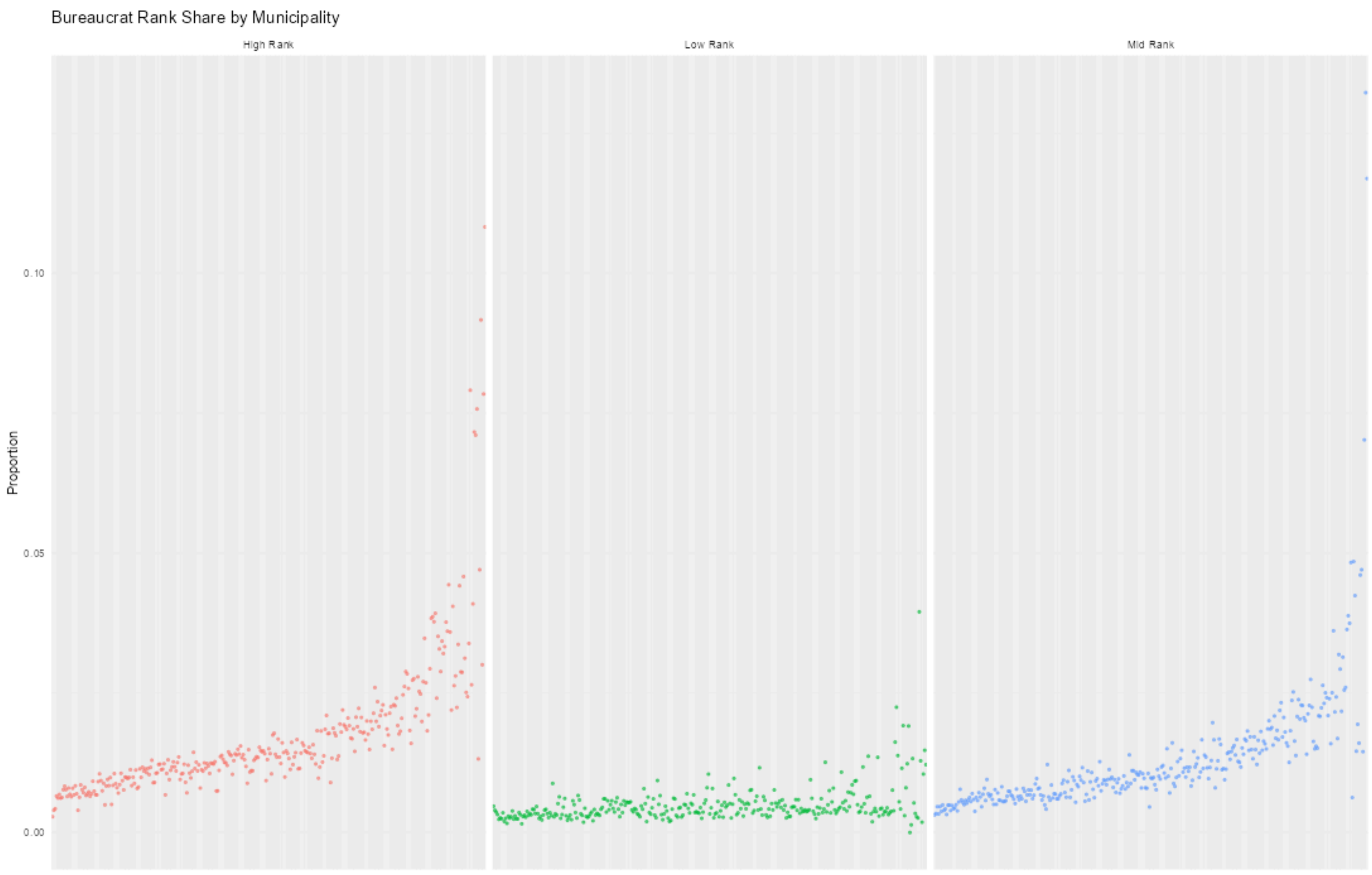
Thanks!

Extras

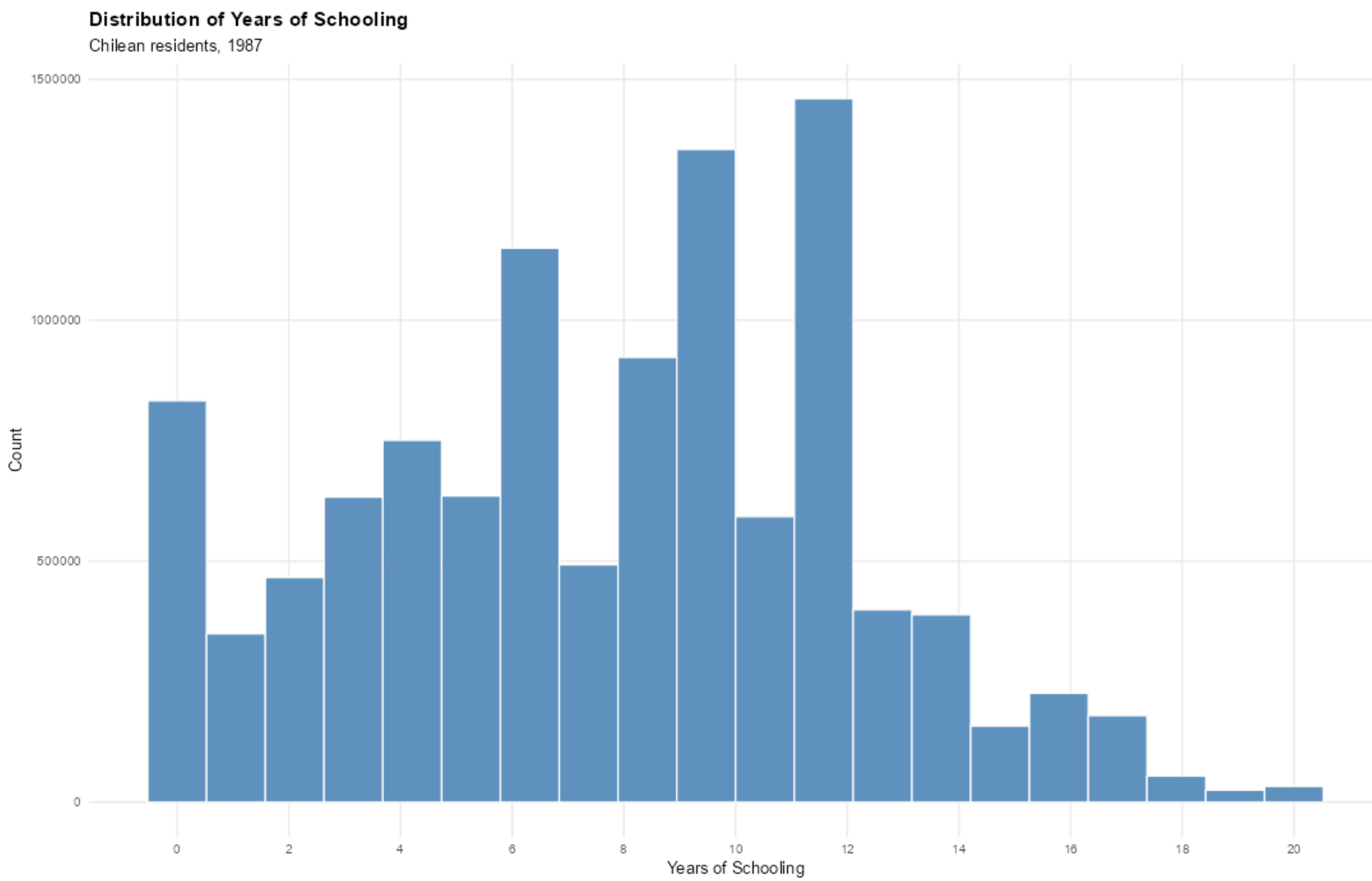
Summary statistics

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N
No vote share	47.63	12.80	3.26	76.77	336
Allende vote share 1970	35.21	13.22	4.17	76.78	324
Proportion of bureaucrats	3.39	1.83	1.06	11.07	317
High rank bureaucrats	1.67	1.14	0.28	9.17	317
Mid rank bureaucrats	1.23	0.81	0.31	7.02	317
High rank share among bureaucrats	48.26	9.49	13.33	91.23	317
Mid rank share among bureaucrats	35.67	7.75	7.20	63.45	317
Total victims / Pop. 1970	2.45	8.55	0.00	132.72	291
Military presence	0.11	0.32	0.00	1.00	342
Ln distance to regional capital	3.72	1.40	0.00	7.11	342
Population 1987	34460.12	51160.04	218.00	299983.00	317
Share rural population 1970	53.04	31.46	0.00	100.44	331

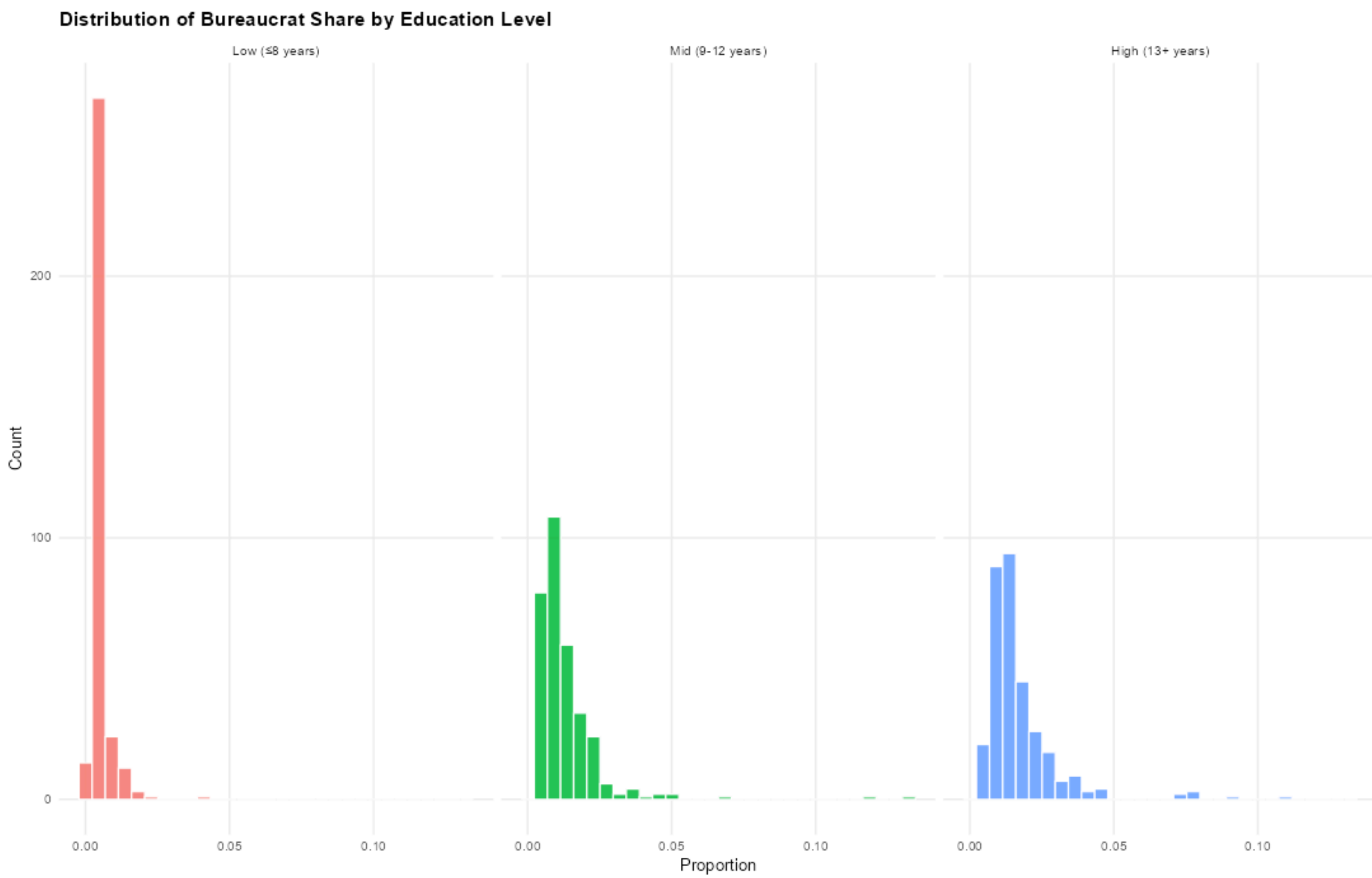
Bureaucrat rank share by municipality



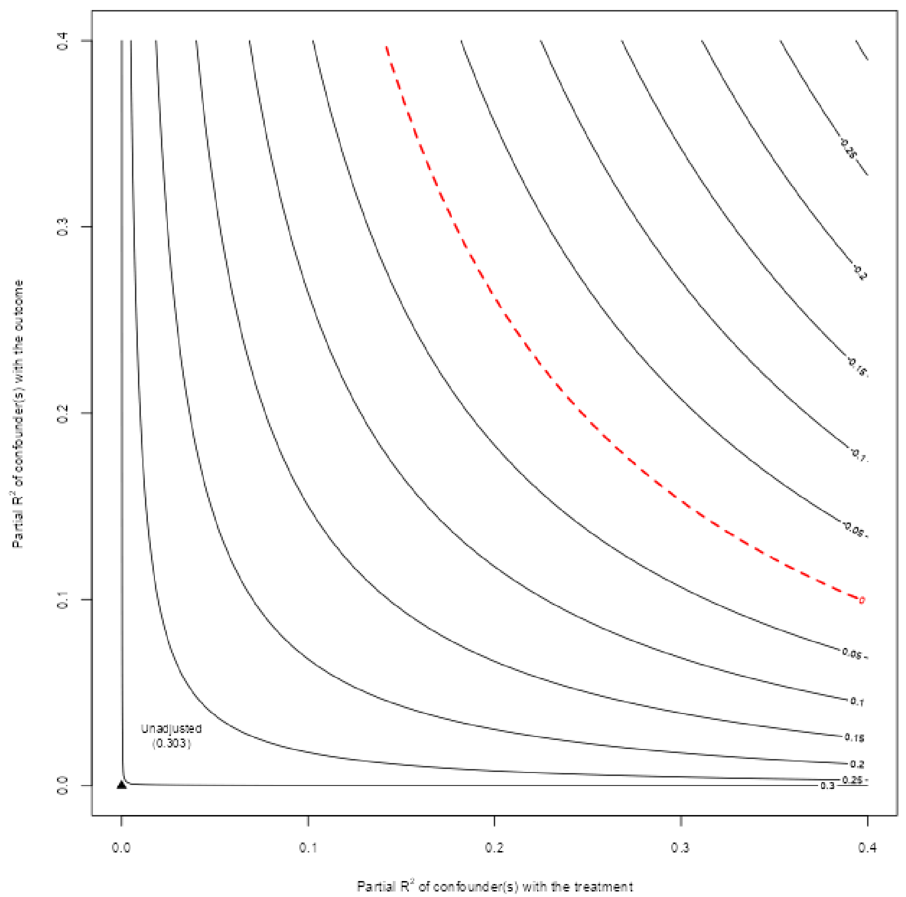
Distribution of years of schooling



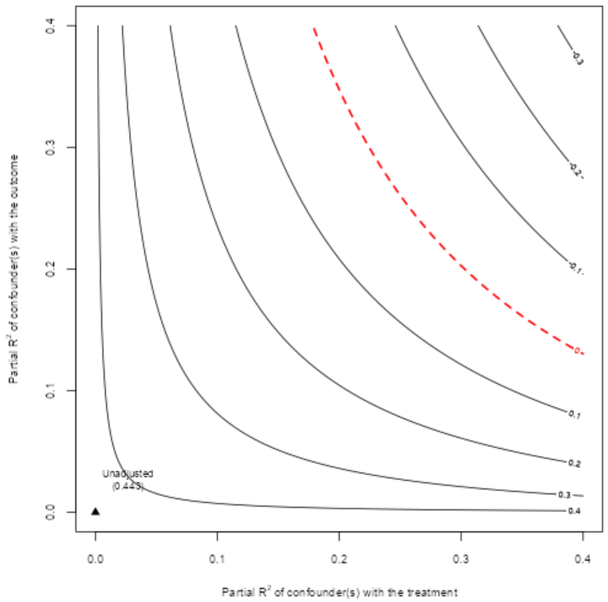
Distribution of bureaucrat share by education level



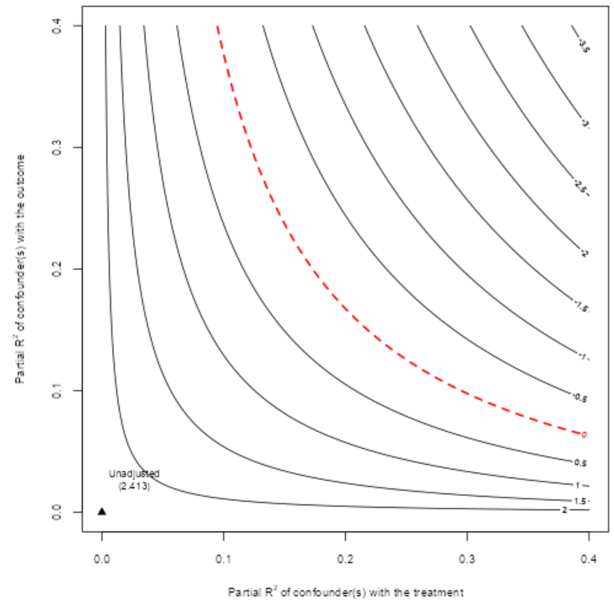
Sensitivity test: High-rank bureaucrats



Sensitivity tests: Mid-rank bureaucrats



Share among bureaucrats



Share of total population